

Only strictly enforced laws and vigilant communities can **PROTECT OUR DYING RIVERS** and exploited coastal areas

Rivers, known as mother rivers in many local to regional languages, dialects and cultural idioms, are known as bedrocks of civilisation. River valley populations in the hilly gorges are thus civilisations within our larger civilisation. Land, water, the forests, aquatic and mineral wealth of these river valleys are rarely valued. The inhabitants who range from Adivasis to farmers and labourers, artisans to fish workers are dependent on the resource matrix in the valley, which is rich in its livelihood value but not necessarily in market value. Rural communities forming part of river basins are therefore prosperous in natural resources, as also human wealth, but are not recognised as such. Their existence on the river banks, farming prime agricultural land, invariably with highly productive silt and green cover, is also a factor in the conservation of an indigenous culture with hundreds of monuments, mostly not even surveyed.

The issue of distribution of river waters was once the most critical of the riverine problems, which created conflicts among Indian states. Tribunals appointed under the Inter-state Water Disputes Act, 1956 followed. These were dealt with so-called scientific measures, with structural development plans. Whether the Cauvery or Narmada, even a decade-long effort by the tribunals and the stipulations in the awards related to the sharing of benefits and costs have not resolved the conflict. The awards stand challenged, as in the case of Cauvery, Krishna and Narmada, where the ground reality has been far from expected. Here begins the conflict between

the state and its people.

Will the inter-state or intra-state rivers ever be rid of conflicts? The answer is not to be an easy one and it, in turn, is rooted in many questions. The first, to whom do the resources in the river valley belong? If not the inhabitants, is it only the state governments with administrative jurisdiction dividing the river valley? Does the process of planning begin with natural and human resources? How democratic, just and equitable is it?

Rs 1 lakh cr

WAS SPENT ON IRRIGATION ACROSS INDIA, BETWEEN 1991 AND 2004, NOT ADDING AN ACRE OF NET IRRIGATED AREA.

